

7-2 Final Project Part II Milestone Three: Problem-Solving and Conflict Management

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Abstract

This milestone reflects on four organizational scenarios and demonstrates the Mark Zuckerberg's leadership at Facebook. It includes an analysis of various organizational leadership situations dealing with skills assessment, team-building, vision and culture, problem solving, and conflict management.

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Our textbook states that changes in organizations as well as generational changes have increased the importance of conversations (DuBrin, 2015). Modern leadership networks must include the peer, operational, personal, and strategic partnerships in order for an organization to effectively deal with conflicts. Some important elements of effective conflict resolution include:

- backing up conclusions with data
- being credible
- writing crisp, clear memos, letters, and reports

Listening is a fundamental management and leadership skill (DuBrin, 2015). It is critical for leaders to use straightforward language and to speak slowly and clearly. It is also important to focus on interests, not the positions opposing sides take when in conflict.

Problem Solving

Our textbook defines creativity as the production of novel, useful ideas and notes that creativity leads to innovation when those ideas are commercialized (DuBrin, 2015). This obviously makes creativity an extremely advantageous trait in any leader. Creative leaders are usually knowledgeable, passionate, possess superior cognition, and have a wide variety of interests. These traits often mean that creative leaders are intellectually nonconformist and typically think “outside of the box”.

Mark Zuckerberg fits the description of a creative leader. In his 2015 article for Business Insider, Richard Feloni described Zuckerberg’s goal of reading a new book very two weeks (Feloni, 2015). One title that especially resonated with “Zuck” was Creativity Inc. - the story of how Pixar Animation studio was founded. Zuckerberg wrote on his personal Facebook page:

“I love reading first-hand accounts about how people build great companies like Pixar and nurture innovation and creativity.”

This shows that Zuckerberg is constantly seeking out new information and using new ideas to influence the way he approaches leadership at Facebook.

Nina Zipkin detailed how Zuckerberg explained his creative drive in her 2016 article for Entrepreneur. Zuckerberg is quoted as saying that entrepreneurship is about creating change as opposed to just creating companies (Zipkin, 2016). This novel idea deviated from traditional views of business and Zuckerberg was able to commercialize his revolutionary concepts with Facebook.

Conflict Management

Mark Zuckerberg utilizes the competitive style of conflict resolution. His desire is to achieve his own goals at the expense of the others and to dominate competition. He is known to engage in win–lose power struggles. Cynthia Johnson explained in her 2015 article in Forbes that Zuckerberg doesn’t lose his cool when he's under pressure or in a stressful situation. Instead, he calmly approaches even the most difficult situations because anger doesn’t breed success (Johnson, 2015).

It is widely known that Facebook experienced legal troubles in the early years when cofounder and CFO Eduardo Saverin sued Zuckerberg for getting him removed from the board and diluting his shares of the company stock. Ben Mezrich’s book, *The Accidental Billionaires*, detailed how Saverin and Facebook president, Sean Parker, became embroiled in a heated conflict over the direction of the company (Mezrich, 2009). When Zuckerberg was forced to address the issue, he did not hesitate to act in his own best interest and forced Saverin out.

Zuckerberg acted in a calculated and methodical manner that ultimately allowed him to further concentrate his power.

Application

Zuckerberg's key strategic business strategies are a preference for moving at high speeds, and gaining a competitive advantage through hiring talented people. In his 2016 article for The Huffington Post, Ali Hanif breaks down how Zuckerberg still uses one of his favorite methods to spur innovation and empower his employees – the Hackathon. Employees from all across the organization from different teams and locations come together to brainstorm and actually build some of the things they truly want and believe will make the experience for Facebook users better (Hanif, 2016).

Zuckerberg uses these events, which happen every couple of months and last for a few days, to unleash the creativity of his organization. He truly believes that by empowering members from all ranks and allowing their products to speak for themselves he is utilizing the most valuable asset any organization has – human capital. The key element of how Facebook stays competitive in the constantly evolving world of social media can be summed up by one core belief that dominates Hackathons: prototypes don't need to be polished, they just need to work in the beginning (Hanif, 2016).

According to our textbook, in order for a leader to make effective use of organizational politics, they must be aware of specific tactics and strategies (DuBrin, 2015). The Facebook process of getting talent from all parts of the company to get together regularly, leverage their infrastructure and actually implement their ideas is a competitive advantage (Hanif, 2016). So by recruiting the best talent and empowering them by allowing for them to be creative, Zuckerberg is able to positively shape the culture at Facebook.

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